

# Narrative Clause Structure Annotation Guidelines

## 1. Task Description

The task sheet indicates segments in each interview where a **story**, a **habitual narrative**, or a **hypothetical narrative** (the definitions of each are given later) is told. For each clause that makes up a narrative, please assign a label representing its micro-structural role and a label representing its macro-structural role. The interviews have already been formatted so that each clause begins on a new line. First, we present examples of annotation; next, we explain the definitions of the various types of narratives, the meaning of each label, and the procedures for annotation.

## 2. Annotation Examples

### 2.1 Story

| Clause id | Clause                | Story | Macro structure | Micro structure |
|-----------|-----------------------|-------|-----------------|-----------------|
| 1         | I have a cat.         | S     | Orientation     | Free            |
| 2         | Her name is “Marumo.” |       | Orientation     | Free            |
| 3         | I love her very much. |       | Orientation     | Free            |

|    |                                      |   |              |            |
|----|--------------------------------------|---|--------------|------------|
| 4  | For example, yesterday morning,      |   | Orientation  | Free       |
| 5  | When I got out of bed,               |   | Complication | Narrative  |
| 6  | and went into the living room,       |   | Complication | Narrative  |
| 7  | we don't sleep together, but         |   | Orientation  | Restricted |
| 8  | Marumo came up to me                 |   | Complication | Narrative  |
| 9  | and rubbed her body against my feet, |   | Resolution   | Narrative  |
| 10 | and that scene is really adorable,   |   | Evaluation   | Restricted |
| 11 | Every morning is like that.          | E | Coda         | Free       |

## 2.2 Habitual Narrative

| Clause id | Clause                                                                 | Habitual | Type of narrative  | Macro | Micro |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|--------------------|-------|-------|
| 1         | When I was a child, I always went to the river during summer vacation. | S        | Habitual narrative | None  | None  |
| 2         | I often caught fish with friends,                                      |          |                    | None  | None  |
| 3         | and swam and played until sunset.                                      | E        | Habitual narrative | None  | None  |

## 2.3 Hypothetical Narrative

| Clause id | Clause                                  | Start/End | Type of narrative      | Macro | Micro |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------|-----------|------------------------|-------|-------|
| 1         | If I had made it to the train that day, | S         | Hypothetical narrative | None  | None  |
| 2         | I could have met him and talked.        | E         | Hypothetical narrative | None  | None  |

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### 3. Explanation of Each Label

#### 3.1 Types of Narrative

Refer to the annotation examples above for concrete examples of each narrative type.

| Label                         | Definition                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Story</b>                  | A long narrative in which the narrator recalls a one-time sequence of events that occurred at a specific point in the past.<br>(A “long narrative” here means a narrative consisting of two or more clauses.) |
| <b>Habitual narrative</b>     | A long narrative about habitual actions, routines, or recurring events in the past.<br>(A “long narrative” here means a narrative consisting of two or more clauses.)                                         |
| <b>Hypothetical narrative</b> | A long narrative about events that did not actually happen.<br>(A “long narrative” here means a narrative consisting of two or more clauses.)                                                                 |

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#### 3.2 Labels Representing the Micro-Structural Function of Each Clause

| Label | Definition |
|-------|------------|
|-------|------------|

|                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>Narrative clause</b></p>    | <p>A clause that reports or describes specific events or actions, or a state or situation that the narrator discovers or encounters as a result of those events or actions.</p> <p>Example: in “I woke up, ate breakfast, and when I went to school, Tarō was standing in front of the gate,” each clause is a narrative clause.</p>                                                               |
| <p><b>Free clause</b></p>         | <p>A clause that conveys information about characters, time, place, or other information that remains true throughout the entire story or narrative. It includes clauses describing states or making comments that hold throughout the period addressed by the narrative.</p> <p>Example: “I have a cat. Her name is ‘Marumo.’ I love her very much,” where each clause is a free clause.</p>      |
| <p><b>Restricted clause</b></p>   | <p>A clause conveying information that is valid only within a certain span of the narrative. It describes states or makes comments that hold from some point up to some point within the period addressed by the narrative.</p> <p>Example: “When I was studying, a friend called,” where the clause “When I was studying” is a restricted clause (studying stops once the phone is answered).</p> |
| <p><b>Hypothetical clause</b></p> | <p>A clause describing events, actions, or situations that have not occurred in reality.</p> <p>Example: “If I hadn’t spent so much time chatting with my friends and had studied more, I could have gone to my first-choice university,” where each clause is a hypothetical</p>                                                                                                                  |

|  |         |
|--|---------|
|  | clause. |
|--|---------|

### Micro-Label Decision Chart

- Does the clause describe events, actions, or situations that have not occurred in reality?
  - **Yes** → Hypothetical clause
  - **No**
    - Does the information conveyed in the clause fall into any of the following categories (1–3)?
      - **A one-time event or action:** something that occurred or was supposed to occur or might occur at a specific point in time or period.
      - **One iteration of a repeated event or action:** one cycle within a longer period of repeated actions or events.
      - **A discovered persistent state:** a static state that continues for a certain period but is narrated as something the narrator discovered or encountered at a certain point in time.
      - **Yes** → Narrative clause
      - **No**
        - Does the situation described persist from the beginning to the end of the story/narrative?
          - **Yes** → Free clause
          - **No** → Restricted clause

### Supplementary Notes

- For some clauses, knowing the macro-structural role of the clause allows you to infer its micro label.
  - If the macro label is **Abstract** or **Coda** → Free clause
  - If the macro label is **Complication** → Narrative clause
- “A one-time event or action” is not necessarily instantaneous. The following actions are also considered events occurring at a particular time or during a

particular period:

- “I ran for an hour.”
- “Shops in the shopping street were closing one after another.”
- In the example below, clauses 2 and 3 are examples of category ② “one iteration of a repeated event or action.”
  1. Every autumn,
  2. **A large number of leaves that fell from the ginkgo trees piled up along the roadside,**
  3. **and I swept them up,**
  4. and it was really hard.
- In the following example from Kodama (2000), clause 3 is an example of category ③ “a discovered persistent state” (and thus a narrative clause).
  1. Then, when I looked closely at Nyāta’s face,
  2. she has such a cute face, but
  3. **Her pupils were wide open and stayed dilated.**

※ Nyāta[a cat]’s pupils were already dilated before the narrator looked at the face, but this fact is presented to the narrator only when they look at the cat’s face.

※ In clause 2, the fact that Nyāta has a cute face is not presented as something the narrator discovered at that particular point; therefore, it is not an example of category ③ (and thus it is not a narrative clause).
- In a habitual narrative, the speaker may pick up **one cycle** of repeated actions or events and tell what happens and in what order within that cycle. For example:
  1. Back then I often climbed mountains.
  2. I would get up in the four o’clock hour,
  3. meet my friends by train,
  4. go to the destination,
  5. If it was winter, we would reach the summit by sunrise,
  6. return to the foot of the mountain by noon,
  7. and go to a nearby hot spring or sauna;
  8. weekends were always like that.
- In such cases, the clauses reporting the actions or events in that one cycle (2–7

above) are classified as narrative clauses.

- All clauses that make up a hypothetical narrative are classified as **hypothetical clauses**.

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### 3.3 Labels Representing the Macro-Structural Function of Each Clause

| Label              | Definition                                                       | Supplementary notes                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Abstract</b>    | The part that states the summary or main point of the story.     | Before telling a story, the narrator may convey the essence of the story. The abstract fulfils this role. Like the coda, the abstract is often missing from a story or narrative.                                           |
| <b>Orientation</b> | The part that introduces characters, time, place, and situation. | Because in conversation speakers' attention is typically focused on the present, when they talk about past events they must set the scene for the listeners and guide them back to that past scene. Orientation serves this |



|                     |                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                     |                                                                                                                                                                   | role.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| <b>Complication</b> | <p>The part that conveys “what happened.”</p> <p>The core part of the story or narrative.</p>                                                                     | <p>The complication contains the progression of past events. By definition, a story/narrative can consist solely of the complication; there are narratives made up only of the complication and the resolution.</p> <p>Sometimes the complication is interrupted, with evaluation clauses inserted to provide commentary, or orientation clauses inserted to add or supplement information.</p> |
| <b>Evaluation</b>   | <p>Clauses where the narrator, a third party, or a character expresses an evaluation, emotion, or interpretation of the events described in the complication.</p> | <p>Telling a story occupies a lot of time. To justify taking up a substantial portion of the shared conversational time, the narrator must convince listeners that the story is worth the time.</p> <p>Therefore, the narrator</p>                                                                                                                                                              |

|                   |                                                                                                          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                   |                                                                                                          | uses evaluation clauses to emphasise the significance or point of the events, or interprets the events for the listener.                                                                                                             |
| <b>Resolution</b> | The conclusion of the sequence of actions or events; the result of the complication.                     | At the end of the chain of complications, the resolution conveys the final outcome of the series of events.                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Coda</b>       | The part that brings the narrative back to the present and indicates that the story/narrative has ended. | By explaining how the events or outcomes reported in the resolution affect the present, the coda prevents further questions such as “What happened next?” Like the abstract, the coda is often absent in many stories or narratives. |

### Complication/Resolution Decision Chart

- Is the micro label of the clause “narrative clause”?
  - **No** → The clause is neither a complication nor a resolution.
  - **Yes**
    - Does the clause convey the final event or conclusion of the sequence?

- **Yes** → Resolution
- **No** → Complication

## Methods for Determining Other Macro Labels

- For the other macro labels, compare the role of the clause within the overall story or narrative with the definitions of each label to make your judgement.
- Several features can help identify the macro label. The checklist items below are neither necessary nor sufficient conditions, but the more boxes a clause checks, the more likely it is to have the associated macro label.
  - **Abstract**
    - Concisely conveys the summary or point of the story/narrative.
    - Placed at the beginning of the story/narrative.
    - The micro label is a free clause.
  - **Orientation**
    - Describes who, where, when, etc., sets the scene, and introduces characters.
    - The micro label is a free clause.
    - The micro label may be a restricted clause.
    - Describes a static state (e.g., “We have a dog. His name is Pochi, and he’s very cute.”).
  - **Evaluation**
    - Expresses the narrator’s or characters’ evaluation, emotion, or attitude toward the events described in the narrative clauses.
    - The narrator stops advancing the narrative to evaluate events that have been told or will be told.
    - Intended to show the point or significance of the story.
    - The micro label may be a restricted clause.
    - The micro label may be a free clause.
  - **Coda**

- Functions to return to the present point of view.
- The micro label is not a narrative clause.
- Describes events that do not fit into the sequence of events told in the narrative and that continue into the present (e.g., “He was actually a detective, and I still occasionally see him.”).
- Expresses effects, repercussions, or influence on the present of the narrative (e.g., “Since then, everything has been fine,” “And they lived happily ever after.”).

### Supplementary Notes

- Researchers of narrative have observed that, when people orally recall past events, the stories they tell typically have the following structure:
  - Abstract
    - ↓
  - Orientation
    - ↓
  - Complication
    - ↓
    - ...
  - Evaluation, Orientation
    - ↓
    - ...
  - Complication
    - ↓
  - Resolution
    - ↓
  - Evaluation
    - ↓
  - Coda
- Therefore, the position a clause occupies within the narrative gives a rough

indication of its macro label.

- Even within clauses classified as narrative—and thus part of the complication or resolution—the narrator’s evaluation or attitude can be expressed using emphatic vocabulary, repetition, emphatic constructions, or comparatives. This is called “evaluation from within.” However, in these guidelines we label only “evaluation from outside,” where an entire clause is devoted to expressing the narrator’s evaluation or attitude toward the events described in narrative clauses.
- A single clause can sometimes describe past habits, but these guidelines consider a habitual narrative only when two or more clauses describe a habit. Such “longer” habitual narratives may exhibit the same structural components (Abstract, Orientation, ···, Coda) as stories.
  - **Example of a structured habitual narrative**
    1. Anything done to excess is no good. – Abstract
    2. When I first lost my job, perhaps because of anxiety, I became unusually enthusiastic about moving my body – Orientation
    3. I would get up in the morning and do radio exercises, –  
Complication
    4. run ten kilometres before breakfast, – Complication
    5. go to the employment office, – Complication
    6. go to the gym when I got home, – Complication
    7. and run again at night. That’s how I spent each day – Complication
    8. I kept this routine up for about a year – Orientation
    9. At the time I thought my life felt very fulfilling, but – Evaluation
    10. Perhaps because I overdid it – Orientation
    11. I hurt my body – Resolution
    12. and now I hardly exercise at all. – Coda
- It is unclear whether a hypothetical narrative appears independently of a story. If it does, it probably has a structure similar to a story; therefore, please assign macro labels as in stories.

### 3.4 Labelling Habitual/Hypothetical Narratives Inside a Story

- **A habitual or hypothetical narrative may appear within a story.** In such cases, use the following charts to determine the micro and macro labels.

#### Micro-Label Decision Chart for Habitual/Hypothetical Narratives Within a Story

1. Consider all clauses that make up the habitual or hypothetical narrative as a single unit.
2. **In the case of a hypothetical narrative:** When a hypothetical narrative is told within a story, all of its clauses are classified as **free clauses**.
3. **In the case of a habitual narrative:** Determine whether the habit or routine or repeated event referred to in the narrative is implied to have ended at some point between the start and the end of the story.
  - **Yes** → Label the clauses as **restricted clauses**.
  - **No** → Label the clauses as **free clauses**.

#### Macro-Label Decision Chart for Habitual/Hypothetical Narratives Within a Story

1. Consider all clauses that make up the habitual or hypothetical narrative as a single unit and think about the role of that narrative within the story.
2. Determine the macro label of the **entire habitual or hypothetical narrative** using the methods for determining macro labels.

*Example of a habitual narrative within a story*

| Clause id | Translation                                                     | Macro label  |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| 1         | I used to go for walks with my mother.                          | Orientation  |
| 2         | Not every day,                                                  | Orientation  |
| 3         | After lunch,                                                    | Orientation  |
| 4         | We would watch a little TV,                                     | Orientation  |
| 5         | Then walk around the neighbourhood for about fifteen minutes.   | Orientation  |
| 6         | We had kept this up ever since I started living with my mother. | Orientation  |
| 7         | But then my mother was diagnosed with dementia,                 | Complication |
| 8         | And soon after that my father passed away,                      | Complication |
| 9         | Since then she has been staying at home all the time.           | Resolution   |
| 10        | I'm worried it may be bad for her health.                       | Evaluation   |

Explanation: In this example, clauses 1–6 describe a past habit. While it might be possible to distinguish the roles of individual clauses within that habitual narrative, **the habitual narrative as a whole functions as Orientation within the story**. Therefore, for the macro label, choose “Orientation.”

*Example of a hypothetical narrative within a story* (based on but modified from Riessman 1990’s “Steve”)

| Clause | Translation                                                                    | Macro label |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| 1      | Just before we decided to divorce, something like this happened:               | Orientation |
| 2      | I suggested to my wife that we go to our cottage in Karuizawa on Friday night. | Orientation |
| 3      | <b>After work we would get in the car,</b>                                     | Orientation |
| 4      | <b>We’d arrive after an hour or two,</b>                                       | Orientation |
| 5      | <b>We’d sleep in on Saturday morning,</b>                                      | Orientation |
| 6      | <b>Have some coffee,</b>                                                       | Orientation |
| 7      | <b>Take our time relaxing,</b>                                                 | Orientation |
| 8      | <b>There’s a small concert at a nearby café,</b>                               | Orientation |



|    |                                                              |              |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|
| 9  | If we went to listen to it,                                  | Orientation  |
| 10 | We both could have enjoyed it.                               | Orientation  |
| 11 | But she asked, “What about the cats?”                        | Complication |
| 12 | I said, “Maybe we could leave them with your mother.”        | Complication |
| 13 | Then she said, “I don’t want to.”                            | Complication |
| 14 | And she kept finding reasons to reject my suggestion.        | Complication |
| 15 | In the end, my wife didn’t want to spend time alone with me. | Evaluation   |

Explanation: In this story, clauses 3–10 describe things that did not actually happen.

While one could analyze the roles of clauses within that hypothetical narrative, **the hypothetical narrative as a whole functions as Orientation within the story.**

Therefore, for the macro label, choose “Orientation.”

- When a habitual or hypothetical narrative is told independently of a story, follow the procedures described in sections 3.3 and 3.4 to determine labels for each clause.

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## 4. Other Notes

- There is no need to assign labels to the interviewer’s utterances.

## 5. References

The definitions of narrative types and macro labels in this guide are based on the following literature:

1. Labov, W. (2013). *The Language of Life and Death: The Transformation of Experience in Oral Narrative*. Cambridge, England: Cambridge University Press.
2. Labov, W., & Waletzky, J. (1967). Narrative Analysis: Oral Versions of Personal Experience. In J. Helm (Ed.), *Essays on the Verbal and Visual Arts* (pp. 12–44). Seattle: University of Washington Press.
3. Riessman, C. K. (1990). *Divorce Talk*. New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press.
4. Riessman, C. K. (1990). Strategic uses of narrative in the presentation of self and illness: a research note. *Social Science & Medicine*, 30(11), 1195–1200.
5. Riessman, C. K. (1993). *Narrative Analysis*. Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications.
6. Riessman, C. K. (2008). *Narrative Methods for the Human Sciences*. Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications.
7. Kodama, Y. (2000). “Possibilities and Issues of Japanese Narrative Analysis Based on the Labovian Model.” *Japanese Language Institute Bulletin*, 10, 17–32.

Definitions of the micro labels were consulted from the following sources:

1. Kodama Yasue. [What is necessary for an interesting story to truly become interesting] Omoshiroi hanashi ga hontō ni omoshiroi hanashi ni naru tame ni hitsuyō na koto (in Japanese). *Shakai Gengo Kagaku* (Japanese Journal of Sociolinguistics). 2020; 23(1): 178–193.

2. Kodama Yasue. [Possibilities and issues in analyzing Japanese narratives using the Labovian model] Rabobian moderu ni yoru Nihongo no naratibu bunseki no kanōsei to shomondai (in Japanese). Nihongo Kokusai Center Kiyō. 2000; 10: 17–32.